

THE DAMBUSTERS

THE RAID ON THE RUHR DAMS on the night of May 16–17, 1943, was perhaps Bomber Command's finest hour. It started as an idea in the head of a scientist, Dr. Barnes Wallis, chief designer of the Wellington bomber. Wallis determined that a well-placed 6,000-lb (2,700-kg) bomb could breach the massive Möhne and Eder dams. He devised a "bouncing bomb" that would skip across water, hit the side of a dam, and detonate after sinking.

An elite bomber force, 617 Squadron, was created specifically for the mission. Led by 25-year-old Guy Gibson, its aircrews included Britons, Australians, Canadians, New Zealanders, and even a couple of Americans. They would have to drop their bouncing bombs at an exact altitude and distance from the dam wall at night and under fire. To achieve the precise flying height of 18.3m (60ft), the Lancasters were equipped with a pair of spotlights angled to meet on the surface of the water when the aircraft was at the right altitude. The bombers were also equipped with VHF radio so that Gibson could control operations.

BOMB DESIGNER

The idea for the bouncing bomb sprang from the brain of Dr. Barnes Wallis, who later developed the concept of a swing-wing fighter.



BOUNCING BOMB

The Lancasters were adapted to carry Wallis' bouncing bombs under the fuselage, rather than in the bomb bay. An electric motor put backspin on the bomb before it was released. This helped it to hop over the antitorpedo barrier in front of the dam and sink straight down after hitting the dam, so it would detonate right against the concrete wall.

A total of 19 Lancasters set out for the Ruhr dams just after 9:00pm on May 16. Five were shot down or forced to turn back before reaching their targets. At the heavily defended Möhne dam Gibson made the first bomb run, skimming in low through heavy flak, his gunners furiously returning fire. Gibson's bomb exploded against the dam but it was not breached. The next Lancaster was hit by flak and crashed into a hillside. Three more bomb runs were made, this time with Gibson and another Lancaster flying wingtip-to-wingtip with the bomb-carrying aircraft to distract the German gunners and concentrate fire on them. After a third hit, the dam at last broke, releasing a racing flood of water down into the valley below.

Later in the night the Eder dam was also breached and two other dams were damaged. The cost was heavy – eight of the 19 Lancasters were lost – and, although the raid was good for British morale, the material effect was limited.



LANCASTER CREW

Wing Commander Guy Gibson (left) poses with members of the crew of his Lancaster, including bomb-aimer "Spam" Spafford on his left and navigator Terry Tærum, far right.



DAM BREACHED

A representation of the raid (left) by war artist Frank Wooten, and an aerial reconnaissance photograph (below) shows the breach in the Möhne dam and water flooding into the valley below.

